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Nancy Wilson

Nancy Wilson's long and illustrious career has encompassed both the jazz and popular music fields. She was born in Chillicothe, Ohio, in 1937 and appeared in local television shows and clubs while still in high school, later gaining performing experience with the Rusty Bryant band. In 1959, Nancy sat in with the Cannonball Adderley Quintet and her career began in earnest. She signed with Capitol Records and subsequent records with Cannonball and George Shearing established her as one of the country's hottest singers. Nancy's extensive list of recordings have embraced a wide range of styles and her accompanists have included jazz greats Chic Corea, Joe Zawinul, Hank Jones and George Shearing. She continues to tour the country and the world and remains one of America's most respected vocalists.

Nancy was interviewed in New York City on November 16, 1995 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, and it's a great pleasure to have one of the finest vocalists in music, Nancy Wilson. Welcome.

NW: Thank you very much. I'm proud of what you guys are doing — I think it's fantastic.

MR: It's been a marvelous experience for us. I want to read something that was written about you in Leonard Feather's first *Encyclopedia of Jazz*. "Admired by George Shearing and other musicians who have predicted a bright future for her, she has shown a promising combination of sensitive phrasing, secure intonation and a strong jazz feeling." So — I think you've fulfilled their future prospects.

NW: That's pretty good. It works, yeah. The thing that was so wonderful about it is, and I have to say about jazz critics, they really gave me the fits for a while. They felt that the Cannonball Adderley album was a compromise for Cannon. Because I was a pop artist.

MR: No kidding?

NW: Oh, yes. You don't know the stuff they did to us. But my point that I've always tried to stress is I came into this business with a gift, the voice is a given. It was a gift from God. I didn't put any labels on it. I also decided to leave my home to do this, to be commercial. I mean the object of the game for me was why would I want to, why would anybody in their right mind want to give up their security, their home, all the things that mean happiness to me, to go out to only want to fulfill somebody else's idea of who and what I am. I figured that I was going to do this on a major scale or I didn't want to do it. Because I could go home, go to Carnegie Tech as opposed to Central State, and be a doctor or be something in medicine, and I'd have been fine. But the voice was always out front. But I have never apologized for being a commercial artist. That is why I do what I

do, is to sell. I want to be heard, I want to reach as many people as I can. I believe in that mass thing. You know I want everybody to know who I am if I'm going to do it.

MR: There's nothing wrong with that.

NW: So when I listen to the things that Leonard — Leonard Feather used to get on me. It would be I was not as jazz, I mean I was not a true jazz artist. Well I've never professed to be. What does that mean, being a true jazz artist?

MR: Good question. What does a true jazz vocalist mean? Do you have to scat? Do you have to —

NW: Well if that's what it means, then I'm not, because I don't scat. I'm not a scatter. I think being true to yourself, being able to improvise, to leave the melodic structure, being able to be sensitive to — see I'm a lyricist as opposed to hearing the intonations and where the music is going. I believe in the spoken word first. So I came at it as an actress before I came to it talking about the music. So the music is, it's all in my ears. I mean I don't, I've never studied this. I am not a person who can give you lectures on what is jazz. I can't really discuss the music too well with you. But I do know what I like. And I know the gift that I have, and I've tried to use that wisely. So I just want to put the jazz in perspective, for me. I sing songs.

MR: Right. Well I felt that way too because I think of you as one of the finest vocalists in music, okay, because I know your career has encompassed a lot of things. This particular album, I can't imagine anybody saying anything bad about it.

NW: Oh it was the fact that Cannonball Adderley had kind of stepped out of the jazz thing, into the pop. Because this was a huge across the board album. It was not just a jazz album. "The Masquerade Is Over," "Sleeping Bee," these songs just popped out everywhere. And that was the good thing about radio in those days and music is that the focus wasn't so narrow then. We were able to play concert venues, Carnegie Hall where we were also able to go into, the south side of Chicago and play The Sutherland. So you could do so many more things then than you can today. The labels kind of keep you out of places. Whereas before we tried to broaden the scope. We, I believe that Cannonball Adderley took jazz out of the sawdust and he was one of the more commercial jazz artists. And he made his audience understand what he was doing.

MR: That's right.

NW: He had a command of the English language, and he talked about the music as though it were truly alive. And he made everybody know what he was talking about.

MR: He, there's been a few people in your career that in the beginning were instrumental I think, and he was one and John Levy.

NW: But before John Levy, and before Cannonball, there was a band called The Rusty Bryant

never signed with Dot. There is supposed to be a record out of me, somewhere, on Dot. And I do believe that was with Rusty Bryant's band. And before Rusty Bryant, because I didn't join that band until after high school, there was a band called Sir Raleigh Randolph and his Sultans of Swing. I was fifteen, and the band's singer. And I played all the cabarets with — in the midwest and in Ohio. I felt really blessed to do that. It was unbelievable to be able to sing all those wonderful songs at a young, very young age. I had a television show at the age of fifteen, so, that kind of made, in my sphere, I was a big fish in a little pond.

MR: Was that in Columbus?

NW: In Columbus, yes.

MR: Was being in that area of the country, was the music different from when you moved to New York? Did you notice a —

NW: No. No I think we were all pretty much on a — at that time — we're talking about time that made the difference, as opposed to where you were. Maybe if you were in, if I'd have been in Kansas City I might have sung more blues or R&B. But what I heard as a child, was Little Jimmy Scott, Nat Cole, Bull Moose Jackson, Laverne Baker, Ruth Brown, Dinah. Basically male influences first. Louis Jordan and the Tympani Five. My father was the one who bought records. Consequently what I heard were male influences. I found Dinah and Little Esther, her first record with Johnny Otis, was what was being played at the juke joint around the corner on Kerdosier's Place. Little Miss Cornshucks. I found I was fifteen before I really heard Ella and Sarah, and it was very much later that I heard Billie. So I came out of more R&B than I did, and blues, than I did jazz. But everybody in Columbus played all of that. We didn't make those distinctions. There was no such thing as Bobby Short and his jazz trio. It was Bobby Short's trio. Rusty Bryant's band. And nobody tagged us. We played – Rusty had hits basically in R&B, but we played, had one of the most brilliant keyboard players Hank Marr, who is now the head of the music department at Ohio State. He's unbelievable. We had some of the most magnificent people involved with the music in Columbus in small clubs like the Club Regal, the Litchford Hotel, there was a little lounge in there where I played. Rusty Bryant and our band started that whole midwest influx where Miles, Cannon, Bill Evans came with Miles, Bill Doggett, at a place called Marty's 502, where we stayed for a long time and the next thing, I mean things got so good that all the major jazz artists came through there. And that's, I met Cannonball though, with Rusty Bryant, in New York City, on the corner standing at 52nd and Broadway. That's where we met. Cannonball had just come up. He was with John Levy. John Levy, I knew the name. If you were in this business, you knew who John Levy was. John Levy was the former bass player with George

did such a good job for George, that just opened the door. By the time I went with John, he had Ramsey Lewis, Gene Harris, The Three Sounds, he had Cannonball, I mean he had so many wonderful artists that he nurtured and made sure that they took care of the business and did wonderful things for them. So the object of my strategy was, if I'm going to do this, the only person who I would trust to help and be there for me would be John Levy.

MR: What a rare commodity — to have a musician, a fine musician, who would step into that role. "I want to be with him."

NW: That you know would care about you as a person as opposed to being in the "show business" mode. I did not have this great desire to be in show business, so I really needed to know that there was somebody out there who would allow me to be a person and to use the music to enhance, but be a part of, as opposed to just overshadow everything else. And John understood that. We met, his assistant was a young man from Ohio, Chuck Taylor. As I say, I met Cannon on the corner, this is when he and Nat, in fact both he and Nat were in New York for one of the first times. This was about the time that Julian [Cannonball] was, they were disbanding their first group, Cannon was going with Miles and Nat was going with Lionel Hampton. So we were, we became friends. We talked, we exchanged numbers. And Cannonball told John, Chuck Taylor had already told John, John Levy was very much aware for several years before I ever got to New York that there is this kid in Columbus, Ohio who sings. So it was kind of, it worked, I mean all of it worked out nicely. I'm just grateful that I was not the kind of person who put the cart before the horse and wanted it to happen all of a sudden. I needed to know me before I wanted to do this. And I figured that if I got to know who I was and put happiness in perspective and knew what it meant to be happy, then I could handle this business. And I could do that with John Levy. I also wanted Capitol Records. I thought David Cavanaugh was one of the best producers. He produced Nat Cole and Peggy Lee, Dakota Staton, Jonah Jones. Because everybody out there — Capitol Records was the singer's label. Johnny Mercer was there. I mean who, what could be better? So I shot for and I wanted that. I wanted MCA which was the biggest agency. I wanted to play supper clubs, I wanted the Coconut Grove as opposed to Sawdust, because I'm going to give this my time and my effort. If I'm going to do it I want it to be right. And John understood that. We talked and when I finally did come to New York, it was at the same week that Julian was first diagnosed and these illnesses were discovered. I was 22. It was in 1959. And when I arrived in New York, Cannonball was in the hospital. And we talked and he was able to go back out and did many, many things. I ran into him in Ohio, obviously, when he was with Miles. But there was this word, this murmur, from Joe Williams and

there's this kid in Columbus. So John was kind of, I just needed to showcase. And when I was ready I came to New York. And within five, I got a job, which was different. I had worked for a minute, you know, other than singing, between high school and college I worked at an insurance company just to make money just to augment that scholarship. Because I didn't want to put that kind of burden on my parents. But because I was already making a decent wage, I mean I was earning a living as a singer, it was very difficult to sit four years in a college. So I went on and joined the band eventually. I went to school for a while, and Rusty Bryant had come after my prom. My prom night I went to see that band. That was a big time band, the Club Carolyn and this was national. And that was in my home town. So the first time I ever heard that band was on my prom night. I sat in with the band that night. And Rusty was at my house the next day asking my father for me to go on the road, which I said no, and my father said, "It's up to her." I'm not ready. So I went on to college.

MR: You knew what you wanted.

NW: Yeah. And I eventually joined the band and traveled in the midwest. But when I did come to New York, I worked — I want all young people to understand that there's a way to do everything. I did not choose to be in New York City without being able to take care of myself. I did not believe that I should come here and say to Cannonball, "Make me a star." I mean we were all musicians and people trying to earn our way into this business. I didn't think that was anybody's responsibility but mine. So I came here, went to the telephone company, learned to work a PBX machine, it was a phone operator, went to Triangle Handbag Company in the garment district for a little bit, and then I ended up as a secretary to the dean at the New York Institute of Technology. Because the hours were from twelve to eight. And I could sing at night, do my daytime thing, and they also were very understanding. And when it came time to go to California to record, when it came time for photo sessions and, I always had the leeway to go do what I — they were very supportive of what I was trying to do. So I really am grateful to the New York Institute of Technology, and to Cannon for when I did get here. There was a young lady who still lives here in New York, she was the band singer with Johnny Hammond Smith. She was my, we were roommates when I first came to New York. We hung out and just sat in at places. We went to the Blue Morocco in the Bronx within a matter of ten days, two weeks after I arrived in New York. Irene Lee broke her leg, I stayed there until I moved to California with the first album. I sang there four nights a week I think it was. Once I had a place to sit down and sing, then Cannon said, "Are you working." "Yep, I'm working." John Levy came, and said, "I'll call you tomorrow." And that following week I was in the studio with Ray Bryant's trio. We did four demos, which were recorded within

of that year. I came to New York in October. I had John Levy, MCA, Capitol Records, David Cavanaugh, and a new album in the can by January 15th. So that's kind of —

MR: So you could call your dad and say, "Hey, it worked." That was wonderful.

NW: And I was blessed here again. My people were not show business people. They did not push. They wouldn't have known how. It was, the music was in my face, all the, from the time I was a little kid.

MR: Some of our greatest piano players have had the pleasure of accompanying you. George Shearing and all the way up to the Griffith Park band.

NW: Yes, Chick Corea. And I just did a show, night before last, with Billy Taylor's trio for National Public Radio. And although we have worked together, this we did at least eight numbers and it was so much fun. Gene Harris, Ramsey Lewis, Joe Zawinul — oh. Joe Zawinul made a statement that, and he said it a little rougher than this, but that there's nobody in the world that can play for you like I can. He was the most brilliant accompanist. Because he came out of, he was Dinah Washington's accompanist. And he came to the ballad as no one else did other than Jimmy Jones. And I did so many albums with Jimmy. He was one of the most brilliant arrangers of all time.

MR: Oh, "The Masquerade Is Over" — what he plays behind it.

NW: That's Joe Zawinul. He's wonderful, truly.

MR: And you're traveling like crazy these days, right?

NW: Um hum.

MR: You were just overseas?

NW: Japan — I'm always in Japan. Yeah. I go there at least once a year, usually twice. Have been as many as three and four times a year. I have been in Japan and Tokyo more than I've been in Chicago the last five years. My daughters are now young women, they're 19 and 20. I have a grown son. But from the time my son, who will be 33, was 7, I backed off in order to be a mother. I worked enough. But it always was in perspective. The girls are now, I'm working now for me, and I'm working to not work. And I'm going to be out here a little bit more, and have been for the last two or three years. I'm very busy these days, yeah.

MR: I'm interested in how a musician like you chooses songs, especially in the more contemporary, like the song "Now I Know" which you recorded — how do you go about choosing material? Do people present it to you in demo forms?

NW: If they do it properly they should present it to producers as opposed to the artists, or management. If I allowed myself to receive everything that came through, I'm not going to lie and say that I can listen to everything that people hand me. I just can't or I would have no life. I don't think people are aware of the fact, and they think they're giving you

these people ever hear me? Do they have any idea who I am or what I sing? Because a lot of it just has nothing whatsoever to do, I mean there's no way that I would ever do it. I come from an old, traditional stance. I want a story, and I want a beginning, a middle and an end. I would like a song that has meaning, touches your heart. Just recently I have found a song that I would consider R&B that has a hook, which is something that I'm not thrilled with, but the groove is so good that I'm willing to listen to it. But I'm basically a lyric person. I really want to tell a story. I would like songs that deal with relationships, the love of man for a woman, woman, man, children, God. I don't like throw-away songs. I really want to say something.

MR: How is your — I know that you and Joe Williams go back quite a ways.

NW: Joe is new with John Levy. He's only been with him maybe fifteen or twenty years. One of the, if not the best band that I have ever worked with was the Basie band. Count Basie's band swings like no other band ever. There just was never a band like that. Joe Williams was, at that time when Joe Williams was with the Basie band, I mean it didn't get any better than Joe Williams and the Basie band. I love the ballads that Joe sings today but I really love the energy that was there with the Basie band. Joe Williams was one of the nicer people in the world. We, and I say John Levy, were very close. He's still working, and working extremely well. I was so pleased to do the tribute to Joe Williams at the Hollywood Bowl this year. Joe just sings so, I mean he's just magnificent. He's a treasure. Truly a treasure.

MR: We've talked to a good number of Basie alumnus and from other groups too.

NW: The Basie band — ooh!

MR: And no one can quite put it into words, but there certainly is the feeling that you just expressed that that band just chugged along like no other.

NW: It swings. Even today the orchestra is still — if I had my choice, if somebody was going to say to me, you have a choice of an 18-piece orchestra, I would today say the Basie band. So that's great. And I'm also pleased with what Mercer's doing with Ellington's band. And a lot of young players, we worked together at the Ohio State Fair. The band was as crisp, if not more crisp, than I've ever heard that band. They really knocked me out. And we really have worked together more in the last five years I think than I ever did with them in the earlier years. So the bands are still there. I would like to see more venues. I don't want this lost because it's so special. Buddy Rich's band — ooh! Buddy Rich used to have, I don't know how he did it, but he used to get these young guys straight out of college, and he worked them to death. I mean he would crack the whip. That was, if you had to walk on stage — and I did it with this band with no rehearsal — and have them read my show without an error, they did it.

NW: They did it. They could do it. There's only two bands that I would walk on stage with, without a rehearsal, just put the music in front of them. And that's Basie, and Buddy Rich.

MR: That's interesting because they're kind of different.

NW: Very different.

MR: The Rich band was quite young.

NW: Yes they were. But on it. I mean they could read from across the room. They were really happening. It was a dynamite band. Sy Zentner, when I was working some of the night clubs, had a band that was one of the best bands that you would ever want to find in a club. So I've been blessed that I was able to work with big bands a lot longer than most people because I was playing the supper clubs. And they had the Freddy Martin band and I can't remember the name of the band, a fabulous orchestra in San Francisco at the Fairmont Hotel. So they kept those bands a lot longer, and I did more work with those house bands than I did any other time. And it was always a pleasure to go in and be able to use charts. Because I have charts written by some of the greatest people. Oliver Nelson's charts are still so valid today. It just doesn't get any better. And the voicing and the harmonic structure that Jimmy Jones brought to the music. I was lucky. Very lucky.

MR: Did you ever have occasion when someone would write charts for you and did you have opportunities to say, "This isn't working, can you fix that?"

NW: The very first album. Billy May's. We sent those Ray Bryant demos out. And two of the songs that we were doing were from that. And they were entirely different interpretations than they were presented with. And it never occurred to me as a kid I mean, well this isn't right. I want to do — this is not the way I plan to do this. And I mean I found out way later, you did what! But I mean this has nothing whatsoever to do with the way I sing these songs. Billy just said, "Okay m'am, you got it," and brought back in new charts the next day. And I've always felt that if I were honest and up front — it never occurred to me that you don't do that. I've been asked, you know, people, you had to do this, you had to — no. I haven't had to do anything. I did not come up in an era where, like today, young people really allow themselves, they believe in order to make it, some do, I will do whatever you say. And they are molding people, they are engineering the records. They are not, it's not creative anymore. It is being done over there with these little knobs. Finally when you realize you've reached a point where major, million, multiple sellers of records cannot perform the material in person, there is something very wrong with that, very wrong. I was really fortunate, as I say, I researched this quite well. When you surround yourself with people like a David Cavanaugh and a John Levy, you do it with that in mind, that these people seem to care, and I don't, I never had anybody ever say,

didn't do that. So I was fed stories, horror stories of show business. You know you have to do this, you have to do that. I said well I'm not doing that because that has nothing whatsoever to do with me being a singer. If it has to do with my music or me on stage or my performance, then we'll talk. But if it has nothing to do with that, no.

MR: Well it sounds like your musical and career instincts were really well formed in your youth, so that's served you well.

NW: I brought it with me.

MR: When someone would attempt to tell you —

NW: Well I just felt that there has to be another way to do show business. I mean if you're going to do it — I want to sing, I don't want to be in show business. So I've always made that distinction. There is a difference and you can't do it both ways. You can either be caught up in it and become totally involved and allow it to be the master, or you can say this is me. I have to do it this way in order to maintain, to be sane, to be myself. And I preferred, I chose to be me, rather than to be somebody else.

MR: Can you recall as a child, were you always pretty comfortable in front of an audience?

NW: Always. I didn't know you were supposed to be nervous.

MR: It didn't even occur to you.

NW: It never occurred to me that you should be nervous. When I found out I was so grown that it didn't make any difference. Then I found out people actually get nauseous and tremble and shake. Well I don't want to do this if I have to be sick before I go on.

MR: Why would I subject myself to that.

NW: But some people do. Some people just feel that that's a part of it. I like being relaxed. I like taking it in stride. I love it. I keep it in its proper perspective, and it allows me to continue to do it. As long as I do it this way I can do it. As long as I'm able to do it for a little while and go home and get what I need to give you. Because being out here doesn't replenish. I have to go home for that. To be fulfilled, I need to go home in order to sing for you. I have to have that sense of well being and balance.

MR: How long have you been on the west coast?

NW: Since the first, let's see I did the first album in December. The first album came out in April. And I left then and went to Australia and waited for it to start flowing. John and I did that. It was so cute I loved it. I spent months in Australia waiting. And I was not available when the first record started hitting the air.

MR: That's interesting.

NW: I was out of the country working. I had months booked there, and came back, and was a sensation.

MR: This was something that was thought of at the time?

MR: I'll be darned. And wait.

NW: That's John Levy. I love him so, I just love him. So that worked out very well. And I came back from Australia in December of '60 and was married in California. I came here and moved to California. I really prefer it. I'm from a rural atmosphere. I'm from basically outside of the city limits. I'm not an inner city person. I can't deal — I came to New York and the first year it was oh my God these tall buildings and where is the sun, where is the grass, I want to see a tree that is not in Central Park. So I have, it was quite an adjustment for me from the midwest coming to the East Coast. I basically have loved California. And I love the south. I could live in Atlanta. I could live in North Carolina. I like that. But I think I'm forever in California. I'm a desert rat although I'm basically Pisces and I love the water, I do live in the desert. And it's probably because it's more economical. I lived at the beach for years, and then I moved my family to the desert. My husband and I used to have two places at the desert, but the girls and I are back at the beach. So we just have a, I'll tell you I've really been blessed. I'm able to be ten minutes from The Strand, which is one of the few places that has a room that's really amenable for work and good for working. I can take the trio in and we can have a good time in there. I still play Carnegie Hall. I'll be back in New York at the Blue Note actually in the new year again here at the Blue Note, and stay for the week after and do six nights. But I do enjoy New York to play. There's an excitement here you can't find anyplace else. So I do love Carnegie Hall. I have a good time here. Don't want to live here. I want to come here and party, sing, have a good time.

MR: Great. That's what you're going to do tonight. Tell us about your current trio. I know Roy's been with you.

NW: Roy [McCurdy]. Oh forever. Roy and I obviously we ran into, I know Roy from the Cannonball Adderley days. But he's been on the road with me for sixteen years. John B. Williams, who nationally is known on the Arsenio show for five years, but he was with me for ten years before that, and Arsenio, because I'm kind of Mom to him, said, "Mom can I really" —

MR: They got your piano players?

NW: They got my — and Michael Wolff was not with me then but had been with me for five years. So when Arsenio was out on the road with us it was Michael Wolff, John B. Williams and Roy. So he, Mike was, he always told them, told Michael, that if something happens to me, I'm going to do this and he did and he asked. And I know that the men are real happy about that. And this is one of the most loyal people in the world is Arsenio. So I'm very happy for the guys. John B. is back, Lou Mathews, one of the best keyboard players, a magnificent conductor. As comfortable with a trio as he is with a symphony

felt that he could accompany me as well as Jimmy Jones, you know he loved what Jimmy did for me, that he and he just said I'm not ready. I don't think I'll—but he's been with me now for ten years — so— but that's the kind of feeling you want from your musicians.

MR: Sure.

NW: We are like a glove on a hand.

MR: That's great. It's nice to know that he approached the work with such commitment.

NW: Yeah. That was unheard of. I mean it was like "I beg your — what did you say?" "I don't know if I can accompany you as well yet." And he worked at it. Because it is a different thing, being an accompanist as opposed to playing piano. I've had many pianists. Don Trenner was an accompanist as was Ron Elbright and Lou. Many of the other people that have played for me I would not have used the word "accompanist." They are wonderful pianists and play great keyboard. But accompanying is a special art. And Lou Mathews has it.

MR: I think it probably has a little bit to do with ego and looking at the total picture.

NW: No, excuse me. It's ears.

MR: It's ears?

NW: It's just realizing piano players play piano. Accompanists listen to singers. There's a difference, I'll tell you, there's a big difference.

MR: Well, this has really been fascinating.

NW: My pleasure.

MR: And do you have anything to say to a young singer in Columbus, Ohio trying to get to New York?

NW: Sing anyplace they ask you to sing. Use your voice. Work. Learn your craft. And you can't learn your craft at home. You need to work those little rooms. You need to put your music in front of people, not in a studio. You need to work. And this is something they've gotten away from. And we need rooms for these young people to learn their craft. We need more little Club Regals and more little places for kids to play. More places where you can just go and just have a piano if you can't have a rhythm section. The object of the game is to put your music and put yourself in front of people. You don't learn your craft just in front of a microphone.

MR: Great. Thanks so much for your time. I hope you have a great gig tonight and the rest of your travels.

NW: Woah, shortly.

MR: On behalf of Hamilton College it's been a great pleasure.

NW: One of these days, hopefully, I will be on the campus and walk through, and get to see

MR: Boy, that would be a thrill.

NW: Thank you for asking me.

MR: Thank you.